EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Why Are the Wicked Rewarded in This World?

Given Monday 13 January 2025 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 5:1-2

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 5 (Merits and Demerits), Chapter 1 and the first part of Chapter 2

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 13 January 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Halfway Through the Book

The first shiur after the winter break. The Rabbi noted that the series had begun almost exactly a year earlier, and that the class was now "about halfway" through Rav Saadia Gaon's book, even though it was only beginning the fifth of ten essays: "the big ones, the major ones, are the first three, four. Other ones are relatively smaller." The plan, be'ezrat Hashem, is to complete Emunot VeDeot during 2025.

A recap of the year

	Subject
Introduction	Saadia's purpose in writing; what *emunah* is; the ways a person reaches wisdom; and the reasons people deny HaKadosh Baruch Hu
Essay 1	Proof that **there is a Creator** (not yet "what we call HaKadosh Baruch Hu," only that the universe has a creator), against **thirteen** views of how the universe came to be
Essay 2	**Hashem** as we conceive Him: His **unity**, the **anthropomorphisms** of the Torah, and a couple of chapters disproving the Trinity
Essay 3	**Revelation**: the Torah; the categories of mitzvot (the rational ones and the revealed ones, which we need Hashem to give us); reasons for the mitzvot; and **prophecy**: what a prophet is, the case of Yonah, and how a prophet proves he is true
Essay 4 (Sukkot to the end of 2024)	**Free will**. The universe was created for human beings, who are the pinnacle of creation and have been given free will, proved from the senses, logic, the Torah and tradition

Believing in the right God

On Essay 2 the Rabbi added a point he has made before. **The Rambam** rules that a person who believes Hashem has a body is a heretic, even if that is how he was brought up and he knows no better. **The Raavad** objects: it was not his fault, and many people believe Hashem has some kind of body. The Rambam's answer is that such a person **simply does not believe in Hashem**. "It's all well and good saying you believe in Hashem, but if you have the wrong conception of what Hashem is, then you can't say you believe in Hashem."

The logic of Essay 5

- **Essay 1:** there is a creation.
- **Essay 2:** there is a God, correctly conceived.
- **Essay 3:** Hashem has revealed His will.
- **Essay 4: you can choose**.
- **Essay 5: the results of those choices**.

The essay is called **זכיות וחובות**, *Merits and Demerits*. In it Saadia will:

1. list **ten categories of people** (tzaddik, rasha, oved, mamre, kofer and so on) and explain each;
2. discuss **teshuvah**, both repentance for bad deeds and regret for good ones;
3. discuss **theodicy**, why people who seem to be good suffer in this world.

The Rabbi said that **Rabbi Yehudah HaChasid**, some centuries after Saadia, gave this essay special significance and called it **the essay on repentance**. "But it's really the same thing." And on theodicy: there are statements in Chazal, "but as someone who actually asks the question and discusses it" systematically, Saadia is the first.

One curiosity: every essay so far opened with a short introduction before Chapter 1. From this essay to the end of the book, Saadia does not do this again. "Is it because he decides to change his method, or because he felt these don't need it? I'm not entirely clear, but just interesting to point that out."

Chapter 1, Part 1: We Are Judged by the Majority

Saadia opens: Hashem has informed us that **when a person's acts of service are many, they are called merits (*zechuyot*)**, and when his transgressions are many, they are together called **demerits (*chovot*)**.

Of course every mitzvah is a mitzvah and every aveirah is an aveirah. The Rabbi explained Saadia's point as one of **classification**: a person with many mitzvot is classified as a *zakai*, a good person; a person with more sins than mitzvot is a *chayav*. The few mitzvot of such a person are not called his "merits." "He very much views the person as **the sum of the majority of his or her actions**." Saadia will develop this throughout the essay, and the class will need to discuss how it fits with what they learnt in the **Rambam's Hilchot Teshuvah**: "I don't know if it goes so finely or not."

Chapter 1, Part 2: Hashem Sees Everything

Hashem remembers and watches over everything a person does: **גדל העצה ורב העליליה אשר עיניך פקחות על כל דרכי בני אדם**, "great in counsel and mighty in deed, whose eyes are open to all the ways of mankind." All our merits and demerits are known to Him and guarded by Him.

Chapter 1, Part 3: Every Act Leaves an Impression on the Soul

Every action a person does leaves an impression on his soul. The majority of one's actions make the soul either **pure and pristine** or **murky and dirty**. That is why the Torah says of sin **ונשא עונו**, "he shall bear his iniquity": you *carry* it, because it changes who you are.

"But I don't see it"

You might say: I do good and I don't see any effect; I do bad and I don't see any effect. Saadia answers that though we cannot see it, it is clear to Hashem, and Scripture and tradition both attest to it. Then he works the point through an observation: there are many professions in which the uninitiated cannot tell the expert from the amateur, or good work from bad. Only someone who understands the discipline can.

Discipline	What the layman cannot tell apart
Money changing ("he likes the analogy of money changing; he's given it a number of times")	A good coin from a bad coin
Medicine	The pulse of the veins, contraction from dilation, correct treatment from incorrect
Physiognomy (*kiyafa*)	A person's nature from the lines of his face and hands. "I didn't know there was a word for this discipline." Aristotle believed in it, and so, it seems, did Saadia
Pearls and jewellery	"For most of us jewellery looks the same," but an expert can tell

Saadia's rule: **the more refined a discipline, the more people will be mistaken about it**, and the more people will claim to know it who do not.

The soul is the most refined thing of all. Our physical senses cannot sense the impressions made on it, but they are revealed to its Creator, who made it. (Whether Saadia thought the *nefesh* is something physical or the whole identity of a person will be discussed in **Essay 6**, which is all about the soul.) Hashem compares the soul to the heavens and the stars, and to a **candle**, **נר ה' נשמת אדם**: just as a candle reveals every nook and cranny, as the class would be learning on Thursday night about *bedikat chametz*, the soul illuminates every aspect of a person. Metaphorically, it is even powerful enough to melt gold.

Kosher and non-kosher, permitted and forbidden

"Think about it. This is quite interesting." A person eats two foods, one kosher and one not; both give him the same sustenance, "the same protein, the same everything." A man is intimate with two women, one permitted to him and one forbidden; the action and the pleasure seem identical. To us they are the same. Only the Examiner knows the impact of each on the soul.

When there are more merits, the soul shines and the person "will see with light"; the more sins, the cloudier it becomes.

The Ramchal, some 800 years later, says exactly the same in *Derech Hashem*: everything a person does affects his soul, and the reason we cannot see it is that we live in a physical body. It is all there **in potential**, waiting to shine when it is no longer held back and hidden in the body.

Chapter 1, Part 4: It Is All Written Down

Hashem records everything for good and for bad:

- of the righteous, **ויכתב ספר זכרון לפניו**, "a book of remembrance was written before Him";
- of the wicked, **הנה כתובה לפני לא אחשה כי אם שלמתי**, "it is written before Me; I will not keep silent, but will repay."

Saadia reflects on why the Torah speaks of writing. Hashem gave us speech and letters. We created alphabets to express in writing what we think, and by writing things down we keep them for posterity. Hashem obviously needs no book, but He uses the image of books and accounts because that is how humans operate and understand.

Chapter 1, Part 5: The World of Action and the World of Reward

The end of the chapter begins Saadia's discussion of theodicy, which continues in Chapter 2.

While we live in **this world of action** (not the Kabbalistic *olam ha'asiyah*; he simply means the world where we act), Hashem remembers everything, and He has prepared the consequences in **the world of reward**. He will create that world **when the full number of human beings He has decided to create is complete**.

How this differs from the Rambam

The Rabbi asked what stands out compared with what the class learnt on Tuesday nights with the Rambam. A participant answered: doesn't the Rambam say Olam HaBa is here? "Excellent."

- **Saadia**, and in truth the simple reading of the Gemara: **Olam HaBa is a world that will come into being after this world is completed**, when all the humans who need to be created are finished. Saadia will develop this in **Essay 9**.
- **The Rambam**: Olam HaBa, "the world to come," means the world that comes **for us** after we finish this world. It already exists. "Every action which you do is Olam HaBa or not, and it's here waiting for us."

The traditional sense, the Gemara's 6,000 years, the Rambam does not necessarily accept. But there is also a Gemara that the end of days is only ushered in **when all the souls that need to be created are completed**. When is that? "No idea. I don't think anyone can give the answer to that." In that world everything will be accounted for: **כי את כל מעשה האלהים יבא במשפט**.

Two puzzling lines

Saadia adds that Hashem does not leave people in this world without **some** reward for their good deeds and **some** punishment for their bad ones, "as an indicator" of their status for the time when the next world is created. The Rabbi asked the class how to read this, and offered two readings:

1. The reward and punishment of the next world are given in miniature here, **as a sign** of what awaits.
2. The main reward is in the next world, but **the minority of a person's deeds** are paid here. (This matches what Saadia says in Chapter 2.)

"It's not clear. Let's keep both interpretations in mind." Saadia supports the idea that there is reward in this world from the blessings and curses of the Torah, and from **הלא הוא כמס עמדי חתום באוצרתי**, "it is stored up with Me, sealed in My storehouses."

Chapter 2: The Ten Categories of People

From Scripture and tradition, Saadia lays out **ten levels** of people with respect to merits and demerits:

#	Hebrew	English
1	**צדיק**	the righteous
2	**רשע**	the wicked
3	**עובד**	the obedient (the Rabbi corrected a misprint in the text on screen)
4	**ממרה**	the disobedient
5	**שלם**	the blameless
6	**מקצר**	the deficient, the negligent
7	**חוטא**	the offender
8	**מזיד**	the wilful offender
9	**שב**	the penitent
10	**כופר**	the denier

The ten are **not five pairs**. The tzaddik and rasha, the oved and mamre, the shalem and mekatzer correspond; but the *choteh* and *mezid* are both negatives, and the *shav* and

kofer are not opposites. "It would be wrong to think of these as pairs."

There is also an **eleventh**: the **בינוני**, the person exactly in the middle. Saadia devotes a whole chapter to him, but his point is that the *beinoni*, being exactly half and half, is pushed over by Hashem to the side of the righteous.

Saadia explains categories 1 and 2, then returns to theodicy, and only in Chapter 4 resumes the rest of the list.

The tzaddik and the rasha: like hot and cold

A **tzaddik** is someone whose merits are the majority; a **rasha** is someone whose demerits are the majority. This is how we speak of nature: something is hot when there is more heat than cold in it; a body is healthy when there is more health in it than illness.

So the prophets call kings righteous or wicked by the majority of their deeds:

- **Yehoshafat** is called righteous, though he was rebuked: **הלרשע לעזר ולשנאי ה' תאהב ובזאת עליך קצף**, "should you help the wicked and love those who hate Hashem? For this there is wrath upon you."
- **Chizkiyahu** is called righteous, though **לא כגמל עליו השיב יחזקיהו כי גבה לבו**: despite all the good he was given, he grew arrogant.
- **Yehu** (son of Yehoshafat son of Nimshi) is called wicked, though he stamped out the worship of Baal. He killed Izevel and trampled her body, killed the royal princes and Yehoram. He did something good, but the majority of his deeds were bad.
- **Tzidkiyahu** is called wicked, though he did not let his officials kill Yirmiyahu. He constantly ignored Yirmiyahu's warnings of destruction, entered the alliance with the neighbouring countries that brought Nevuchadnezzar against Jerusalem, and imprisoned the prophet, but he kept him alive.

Payment for the minority in this world

Hashem, in His wisdom, decided to **repay the minority of a person's deeds in this world**, and keep the majority for the next.

Why? Because **in the next world there is no changing position**. Whatever level a person enters it at is the level he stays at permanently: **אלה לחיי עולם ואלה לחרפות לדראון עולם**, "some to everlasting life, and some to everlasting abhorrence."

The Rabbi called this "very important." **The Kabbalists, the Ramchal**, speak of a person rising **from level to level** in the next world, and there is a hint to that in the Gemara: **ילכו מחיל אל חיל**. Saadia rejects it. "Whatever position you enter when you die is what you will be for eternity, for the good and for the bad."

So the tzaddik's sins are dealt with here, and the rasha's mitzvot are paid here: **ומשלם לשנאיו אל פניו להאבידו**, "He repays those who hate Him to their face, to destroy them."

The Rabbi's Question: Is This Fair to the Rasha?

"Let's stop there for a moment. Doesn't that trouble you?" The reward and punishment of Olam HaBa are eternal and incomparable to anything in this world. "Let's be really, really crude here":

	Mitzvot	Sins	Next world	This world
Tzaddik	60	40	Eternal reward for the 60	Punished for the 40
Rasha	40	60	Eternal punishment for the 60	Rewarded for the 40

For the tzaddik this is a good deal: "it's better for me to take it here." But why should the rasha's forty mitzvot be paid off in this world, when even 120 years of a perfect life, "all the pleasures of this world," are incomparable to the reward of Olam HaBa?

Suggestions from the class

- One participant cited the Mishnah in Pirkei Avot that **one hour of bliss in the world to come is better than all the life of this world**. The Rabbi: that explains the tzaddik, "Fantastic. But how would you explain the opposite?"
- Another suggested that perhaps the reward here is of a lower order. "It's still incomparable."
- Another suggested that if reward and punishment were too obvious, free will would be compromised. "I hear it, but it's still not fair to the rasha. You can't give *me* the opportunity to have free will at the expense of the rasha."

Theodicy: Moshe, Aharon and Aviyah

Saadia's examples:

- **Moshe and Aharon** sinned once, at the waters. "Whatever the sin was," and the Rabbi noted there are at least two dozen opinions about what it was, they were punished in this world and could not enter Eretz Yisrael.
- **Aviyah, son of Yerovam**, from a wicked house, did one good thing: he removed the barriers his father had set up to stop people going to the Temple. He was rewarded in this world: **יען נמצא בו דבר טוב**, "because some good thing was found in him," he alone of his family would be buried properly.

So, Saadia concludes, it is possible for a righteous person, with many sins though fewer than his mitzvot, to be afflicted and oppressed his whole life, "as if he doesn't keep anything," and for a sinner with some mitzvot to have a wonderful life, so that people say, "look at this person, he seems to be such a righteous person."

A black and white picture

Mark asked: doesn't that assume the righteous person gets absolutely no benefit in this world for any good he does, "not even a taste of the world to come"? "That's what he's saying. That's a good point."

"The more I think about it, the more I think actually Saadia has a bit of a black and white approach." If life is going wonderfully, either you are a terrible person being paid here, or you are completely perfect. If life is terrible, either you are a tzaddik having your sins dealt with here, or you are thoroughly wicked and will suffer in both worlds. "It's difficult, because it's not really how the world runs, let's be honest about it. Although who are we to be able to judge to understand. But that's his view."

The Rabbi's Answer: It Depends on Who You Are

"I don't like it when people force interpretations into words of Rishonim, and therefore I'm hesitant to do this." But the Rabbi suggested that Saadia's "majority" is not arithmetic. It is about **identity**, an idea that fits the Rambam, and which **Rav Dessler** also argues.

- When Saadia says the majority of a person's actions are good, he means: **that is who he is**. At his core he is good; he wants to do good and does good most of the time. He slips.
- A rasha is a person who is bad at his core. Here and there he does something good.

So a rasha's mitzvah is, "in inverted commas, an *olam hazeh* mitzvah": done for some benefit, with ulterior motives, because his values are this world's. "You are an *olam hazeh* person. And so it's fitting that you have consequences for your actions in *olam hazeh*." The tzaddik's world is the next world. "Yes, here and there I slip, but it's not really who I am. This world is not who I am." So his slips can be dealt with here.

This also explains **the Rambam on the Mishnah** that Hashem gave Israel many mitzvot: since there are so many, a person has the opportunity to do **at least one** properly, "fully, genuinely, completely, no ulterior motives," and by it he earns a portion in the world to come. A mitzvah that is genuine and sincere **cannot be paid off in this world**. So Saadia must be speaking of a person who does more bad than good, whose good is not sincere or complete. "This is what you value. You care about this world. We'll pay you off here. You'll have a great life here."

"Think about it. We'll pick up on it next week."

Summary

1. **The fifth essay**, *Merits and Demerits*, is about **the results of our choices**: the ten categories of people, teshuvah, and theodicy.
2. A person is **classified by the majority** of his deeds.
3. **Hashem sees and records everything**; "writing" is an image for our sake.
4. **Every act leaves an impression on the soul**, invisible to us like the expert's distinctions in money changing, medicine or jewels, but clear to the soul's Creator. The **Ramchal** says the same.
5. **Olam HaBa** for Saadia is a world to be created **after** this one is complete; for the Rambam it already exists.
6. **Ten categories** of people, not five pairs, plus the **beinoni**, who is counted with the righteous.
7. **The majority is repaid in the next world, the minority in this one**, because one's level in the next world is fixed forever (against the Kabbalistic idea of ascent).
8. **The Rabbi's reading:** "majority" means **identity**. The rasha's mitzvot belong to this world because he does; a sincere, complete mitzvah could never be repaid here.

Coming Up

Next week: finishing Chapter 2, where Saadia discusses **regret for mitzvot and for aveirot** and continues the theodicy, and Chapter 3, which is devoted to **why the righteous suffer** in this world.

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